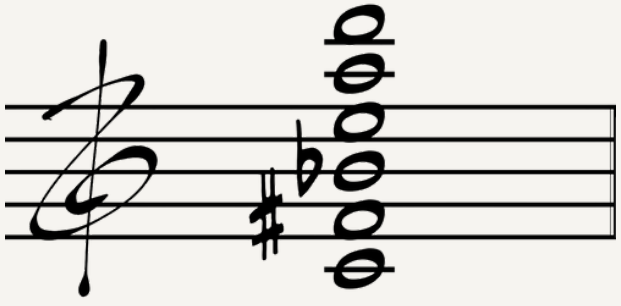


SURVIVAL KIT

For the 21st century musician

www.jazzlabmusic.org

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INDEX



EXPERT ADVICE FOR A 21ST CENTURY MUSICIAN

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Harmonic Matrix

Decode the harmonic templates behind pop/jazz standards — visually. Understand how chord families and secondary dominants operate.

2

Pivot Chords

Learn how to quickly think of all chord possibilities to harmonize one note. This is a useful tool for composition, reharmonization and improvisation.

3

Voice leading

Voice leading is at the heart of good harmonies. Here you'll find a few exercises to develop more awareness and attention to the inner voices inside chords.

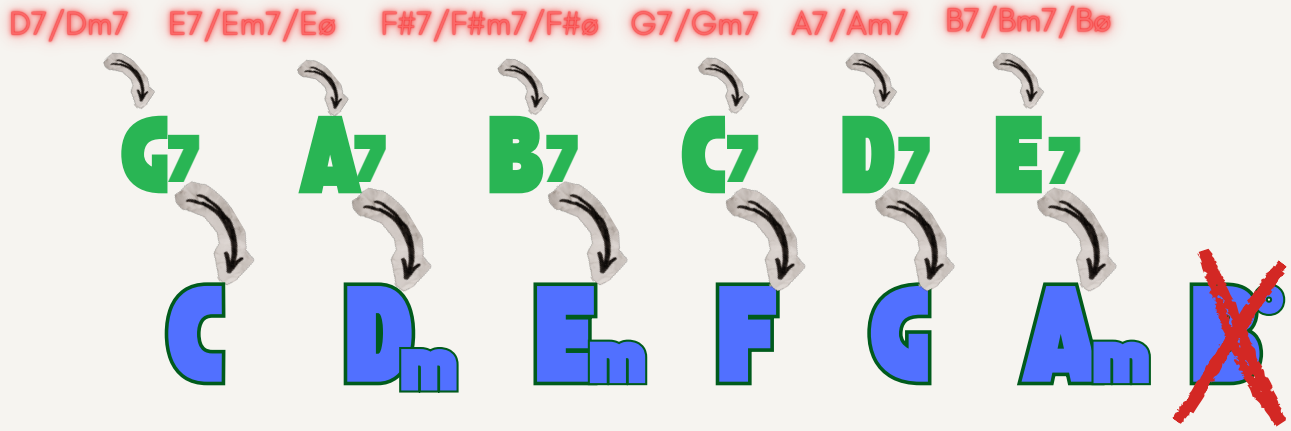
- and other quick advice on musicianship, improvisation, career, practice routines, ear training, etc....

HARMONIC MATRIX

The chord Matrix is a method of organizing chords in a way that helps us visualize and understand harmonic progressions.

By using the concept of "Chord Family" and a system of arrows, it is possible to quickly analyze and recognize harmonic patterns in the music we love, especially Jazz/Pop/Rock.

In addition, we can use the matrix as a powerful composition tool, allowing one to create chord progressions that make sense and constructing forms that feel very natural.

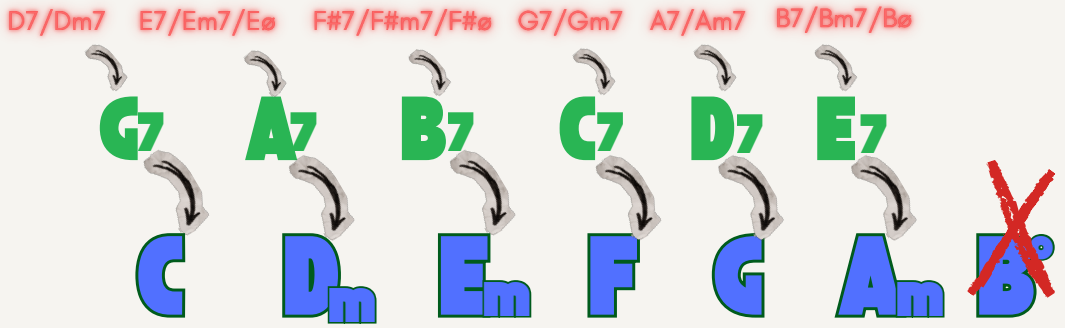


The Blue chords represent the starting Chord family (diatonic chords) of the key of C major (the 7th chord is rarely used nowadays, so it's normally ignored).
The green chords are the secondary dominants (dominant chords a fourth below each blue chord).
The chords in red are secondary dominants as well (dominants of dominants). Due to common practice, I've also included minor chord and half-diminished chords that are often utilized in this context.

HARMONIC MATRIX cont.

In addition to the main chord family and secondary dominants, we can also include the parallel minor family (the diatonic chords from the minor family, in this case C natural minor).

Cm Dº Eb Fm Gm Ab Bb



The minor family offers chordal possibilities that can transform the sound of a piece, darken it, adding a magical veneer. Using a chord from the minor family is generally called modal interchange or modal borrowing.

Being familiar with the chord matrix allows us to visualize the blueprint behind most harmonies, as well as serving as a tool to memorize music more quickly, compose harmonies that make sense, transpose chords more easily and reharmonize other pieces.

For a deeper dive into the Harmonic Matrix and more exercises, check out our Youtube video on "A Semester of Music Theory in 10 minutes", and our other free e-book on the Harmonic Matrix.

PIVOT CHORDS



ONE-NOTE EXERCISE

Pivot Chords

This is an exercise that can accelerate our musical creativity, allowing for unexpected harmonic shifts, rehearmonizations and composition ideas.

Start by choosing one note to be the center of the exercise. In this example, lets choose an A.

A

The next step is to quickly think of the simplest chords (triads) that include the note A. We'll call this TIER 1.

A Am D Dm F F#m

Just by using the chords above you can create incredibly sophisticated music. But we can move to the next level, in which we think of more chords that include the note A. (here the note A will be a tension of another chord). Here are some examples. (TIER 2)

B7 Bbmaj7 Gm9 Cm6 Esus4 Bm7 G9

The last step is to find complex and advanced chords that include the note A. (The options are endless). Here are a few examples. (TIER 3)

Eb7(#11) Ab13(b9) C#maj7(#5) Csus13

PIVOT CHORDS

ONE-NOTE EXERCISE

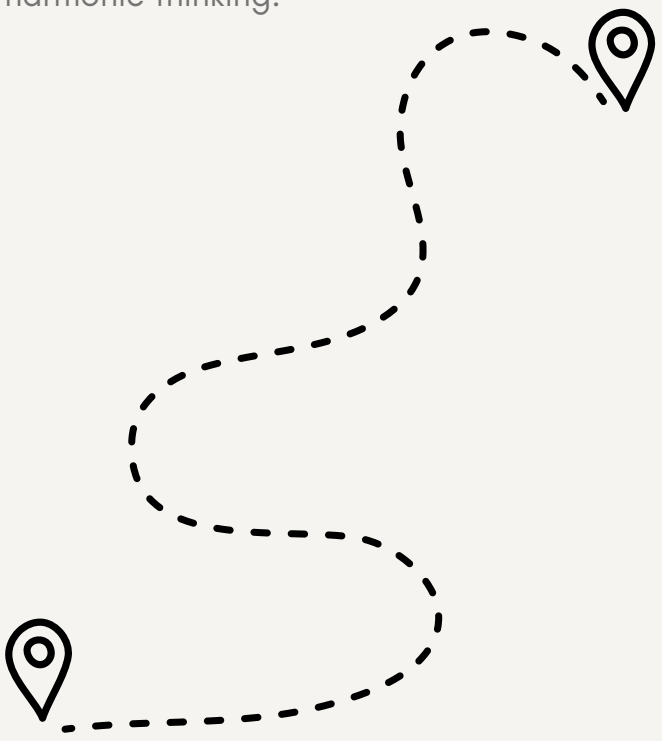
Once you understand the three tiers (the three level of complexity), it's time to create your own progressions.

Here's a step-by-step process:

- Pick your note (e.g., A).
- Create an ostinato rhythm that repeats throughout.
- Choose four chords — mostly from Tier 1, with one or two from Tier 2 or 3.
- Experiment with different combinations.
- Listen and refine.

REHARMONIZATION

Mastering this technique can truly help our ability to reharmonize melodies and come up with surprising harmonic pathways. For example, pick any famous melody of your choice, and choose a specific note in that melody. Quickly go over all the chordal possibilities (Tiers 1, 2 and 3) and experiment over that specific note. You are likely to find unique possibilities that you wouldnt hardly arrived at by traditional harmonic thinking.



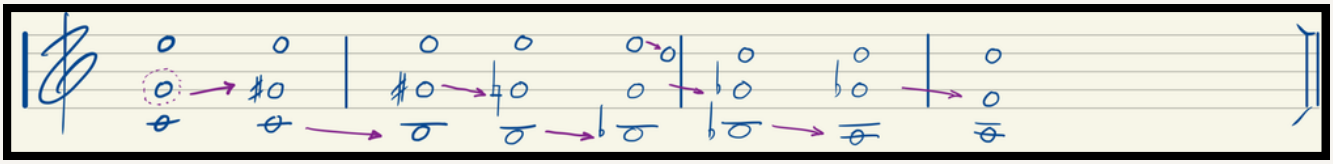
VOICE-LEADING



Voice-leading may well be the most essential fuel behind harmony. Jazz pedagogy often overlooks how crucial it is to preserve good voice-leading — to pay close attention to the individual voices within a chord. Good voice-leading is what makes smooth, seamless chord changes possible, opens the door to unusual modulations, and shapes great orchestration.

Here's a great exercise to focus more on individual voices:

Start with a simple chord, maybe a major triad. Play it as an open chord (the third is played an octave higher se there's more space in between notes). Establish an ostinato or an arpeggio motion. After a few beats choose one of the 3 voices and move it up or down by a half step. The resulting chords don't have to be known chords, good voice-leading allow for bizarre chords to make sense. See the example below:



Overall the progression above is quite unusual, surprising, profound, beautifully ambiguous. PRACTICE: Create a few series of voice-led harmonies without a melody in mind, just playing a chord and slowly transforming it. Get familiar with the different possibilities and sounds you can obtain. Then try applying is to simple melodies. If you hit a wall, you may interrupt the voice leading as a last resort and shift the whole chord, although I believe there's ALWAYS a solution half-step away.

Another great exercise is to try to play a known tune, for example *My Funny Valentine*, and accompany using this principle, starting with an open chord and moving only one note at a time. You'll have to think creatively...

OTHER QUICK TIPS



- Sing everything you play, your voice is the best link of communication between your heart and your fingers. Singing is the best way to make your music feel lyrical, organic and natural.

- True technique is measured by how soft one can play, not by how fast. True instrumental control ris the ability to play softly and precisely.

- Practice imitating your favorite musicians, don't be afraid of mimicking everything they play. Try to imitate a famous musician and have your friends guess who you are imitating.

- Learn as many different genres as you can: classical, early jazz, funk, latin, Balkan, African, pop. The more the better. The best musicians are often musical polyglots.

- Memorize as much music as possible. Force yourself to rely on your ears, avoiding sheet music-dependency. It's hard in the beginning, but it gets easier as you learn how your memory works, and what types of information you need in order to memorize.

- Practice transposing melodies to different keys (and harmonies too), but instead of doing any guesses, take your time, use your ears and your theory to not make mistakes. Don't do it by trial and error, practice developing confidence and accuracy.

- Use creative constraints in your practice. Too much freedom often leads to paralysis. Establish a few rules to your improvisation practice: using a specific set of notes, or only one type of rhythmic motif, or only upbeats, etc.

JAZZ LAB SUMMER

Jazz Lab Workshop for Adults — June 21–27 | New England Conservatory, Boston

- Our flagship programming in partnership with New England Conservatory. For musicians 19+, we'll spend a week playing in ensemble, jamming, and hosting electives in improvisation, composition, and harmony — with faculty concerts each evening throughout the week. On-campus housing available. Visit jazzlabmusic.org/adult for details.

Jazz Lab for Teens — June 28–July 4 | New England Conservatory, Boston

- Now entering its 13th year. Incredible faculty, guest artist Adam Neely, and nightly faculty concerts — giving young jazz musicians the chance to grow and develop while experiencing life as a student at New England Conservatory. On-campus housing available. Visit jazzlabmusic.org/youth for details.



